NICHOLAS ROSS, Ph.D.

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SUMMARY

Hands-on technical leader and startup co-founder with 15+ years building and scaling data and AI products from zero to production. Deep engineering expertise (LLMs, agentic workflows, RAG, cloud infrastructure, distributed backends) paired with the founder's toolkit: setting technical strategy, owning architecture, building teams, and raising capital.

WORK EXPERIENCE

University of Chicago August 2022 - July 2026
Director of Data Science and Clinical Professor *Chicago, IL*

- Headed the DS/AI Clinic, providing technical leadership, architecture guidance, and project definition for a lab of nearly 100 engineers, scientists, and researchers.
- Built state-of-the-art AI proof of concepts (RAG, vector databases, agentic systems) and shipped production work for clients including Invenergy, Morningstar, and AmFam Insurance, spanning computer vision, forecasting, and LLM/agent research.
- Developed some of the first agentic-workflow curriculum at the University; built and ran the Data Science Core Facility (Python, AWS, GCP, PyTorch) and advised startups in the Polsky Center's AI Accelerator.

Classify (www.tryclassify.com) August 2024 - March 2026
Co-founder & CTO *San Francisco, CA*

- Co-founded an ad-tech startup and shipped an LLM-based categorization product operating at internet scale, from concept through commercial deployment with customers including PubMatic and Scope3.
- Set technical strategy, owned system architecture, raised a seed round, hired and led the initial engineering team, and built tooling around agentic workflows (MCP and adCP integrations).

The Meta (not Facebook) June 2020 - May 2022
Director of Backend Engineering & Data Science *San Francisco, CA*

- Built the engineering team and architected backend services from the ground up on GCP (Docker, Kubernetes, Node, Python, PostgreSQL, Redis) for software serving thousands of concurrent users.
- Migrated from serverless to a cost-effective Kubernetes microservices system, maintaining <10 hours of downtime per year, including a zero-downtime paid-to-free-to-play transition.

University of San Francisco January 2014 - May 2020
Associate Professor of Data Science, Director of Practicum & Asst. Director of External Partnerships, The Data Institute *San Francisco, CA*

- Built the Data Institute's external partnership program from zero to 30+ paid industry relationships (∼$200K/year), including PG&E, Facebook, and United Healthcare.
- Co-developed, with ABC News' Decision Desk, an election-night early prediction system that called dozens of federal and gubernatorial races across the 2018 and 2020 cycles.

Sega & TinyCo 2011 - 2015
Director of Data Science / Analytics & User Acquisition *San Francisco, CA*

- Built and led the analytics organizations at two mobile-gaming companies: at Sega, a multi-national team running infrastructure ingesting 250M+ events/day; at TinyCo, the team and $25M marketing budget that grew the user base from 30M to 80M.

EDUCATION

Ph.D, Business, University of California, Los Angeles (Anderson) 2007 - 2012
M.A. in Economics, University of California, Davis 2006 - 2007
B.A. in Applied Mathematics, Honors, University of California, Berkeley 1998 - 2002